

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1996-06-14

To an individual believer

1 your email message . . . has been received, and the universal house of
2 justice has asked us to reply as follows to the questions perplexing you re-
3 garding the house of justice. . . .

your first question stems from a statement made by an individual on

4 an internet bahá'í discussion group which asserts that "Shoghi effendi has
5 describing the house of justice, 'Abdu'l-bahá states clearly,
6 whatever will be its decision, by majority vote, shall be the real truth,

inasmuch as that house is under the protection, unerring guidance

and care of the one true lord. he shall guard it from error and will

protect it under the wing of his sanctity and infallibility. he who

opposes it is cast out and will eventually be of the defeated.228-1

7 nounce upon and deliver the final judgment on such laws and ordinances
8 as bahá'u'lláh has not expressly revealed."228-2 it carries responsibility for the
9 application of the revealed word, the protection of the faith, as well as the
10 duty "to ensure the continuity of that divinely-appointed authority which flows from
the Source of our faith, to safeguard the unity of its followers

and to maintain the integrity and flexibility of its teachings."

11 228-3 however,

12 understand that there is a difference between infallibility and omniscience. like the
guardian, the house of justice wants to be provided with facts

13 when called upon to render a decision, and like him it may well change its decision
when new facts emerge, or in light of changed conditions at some

14 228-1. muhj, no. 23.11, quoted from makátib-i-'Abdu'l-bahá, vol. iii, pp. 500-
15 501.

16 228-2. wob, p. 150. 228-3. cuhj, p. 3.228.1

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

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58point in the future. we have found nothing in the writings of Shoghi ef-

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fendi which suggests that the house of justice would on any occasion reach

a “wrong decision.”

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to men, you are correct in your understanding that bahá’u’lláh was explicit

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about the matter, and consequently it is not within the power of the house

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of justice to rule otherwise at this time or at any time in the future. As to

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the additional information on this matter which “has limited distribution”

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mentioned in the statement posted on the discussion group, it is unclear what this statement is referring to. in 1988, the attention of the house of

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justice was drawn by the National Spiritual Assembly of New zealand to an

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unpublished paper which was being widely circulated on this subject; the comments of the house of justice on the subject were conveyed in a letter

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to the National Assembly of New zealand, a copy of which is enclosed for

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your reference.

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we hope the above comments are helpful in relieving any confusion you

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may have felt related to these matters. you are assured of the loving prayers

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of the house of justice at the Sacred Threshold, that the blessed beauty

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may guide and confirm all of your efforts on behalf of h is cause.

Department of tHe secretariat

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Clarification on Bahá’í Wills

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]